DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Why Do We Call God King?

Derech Hashem 4:4:1-2

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 4, Chapter 4, paragraphs 1 (last part) and 2 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 7 February 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: evil as illusion

We are in the chapter on Kriat Shema, the longest in Derech Hashem, where the Ramhal teaches that the whole of existence is about Yihud Hashem. God created the world to do good to us, and the way He did it was by withdrawing so that evil could exist and we could choose good. All the bad in the world is, in the end, an illusion: it looks as if there are many forces and powers, but nothing can happen without God's will.

There are two kinds of bad: tragedies that happen in the world, and the bad we do. When we sin, at root we are rejecting God's oneness. If we truly lived with the unity of God, we could not sin, because we would see that every tempting sin is an illusion. We cannot see this in this world, only sometimes in hindsight. So we testify to it. That is why we cover our eyes for *Shema Yisrael*: "I can't see the Yihud Hashem, but I believe it to exist." And that is how every Tefillah ends: waiting for the day when all existence recognises that everything traces back to God.

The end of paragraph 1: three aspects of unity

The world runs in two modes, day and night, as learned in Part 3, chapter 1, about the soul leaving at night. The whole system is renewed every evening and every morning, so every evening and morning we are obliged to testify to God's oneness in all three of its aspects:

1. **Existence.** Only God's existence is necessary; everything else depends on Him.
2. **Authority.** He alone rules; nothing can act unless He gives it the power.
3. **Providence.** However complex and roundabout events seem, they all come from one source and move in one direction.

For the third, the Rabbi used the children's maze. A young child watching asks why the pencil keeps going up and down, left and right. The older child sees the whole page and knows the line is heading for the exit. God sees the end, and everything leads there, even if we cannot see it now.

So at the start of each new day and each new night we remind ourselves: I exist, but I do not have to; I am speaking now with free will, but only because God wills me to; and everything in

the world is moving towards the revelation of God's unity. That is what we mean by *Hashem Ehad*.

This is also why Shema belongs at the beginning of the day, ideally just before sunrise, and Arvit at the beginning of the night: "Don't leave Arvit to 11 o'clock at night." And you need not say "with God's help" after every sentence; thinking it through morning and evening is "good enough".

Our part in revealing it

A participant asked: if God allows bad, are good people not expected to stop it? Certainly, the Rabbi said, that is our role. The more good we do, the more we reveal God's unity. Another participant said this begins with our personal lives and the people we meet. "Start with ourselves." If each person works on himself, the world will be a much better place.

Paragraph 2: accepting the King

The second principle of Shema is *Kabbalat Ol Malkhut Shamayim*, accepting the yoke of God's sovereignty, expressed in *Barukh Shem Kevod Malkhuto*.

God's existence depends on nothing, is comparable to nothing, and is perfect in itself. From this perspective we call Him **Elohim**: the God with no association to anything, distant, formal, impersonal. He does not need us.

Because He chose to create beings who depend on Him, we call Him **Adon Kol**, Master of all: everything is from Him and His. That already implies some relationship.

And in His kindness and humility He chose to associate Himself with His creatures as **Melekh**, King: to be regarded as their head and leader, and to be glorified, as it were, through them. A king, however powerful, exists within a relationship with his people. The Rabbi noted that the Queen was about to mark seventy years on the throne, and that, as she herself recognised, a monarch reigns with the support of the people. And the more people, the greater the king's glory, which is why halacha values a larger congregation.

Does God need our service? No. He created a system in which we can, as it were, serve a King, and He is glorified through us. A participant put it well: "We're not serving Him for Him. We're serving Him for us." The Rabbi agreed.

A participant asked why Rosh Hashanah is special if God is King every day. The Rabbi: at that time He is "on the doorstep", and we feel it much more closely.

The meaning of Shema

So in *Shema Yisrael Hashem Elokeinu* we declare He is our God, and in *Barukh Shem* we accept His kingdom. Every morning and every evening we do two things: testify to God's unity although we do not see it, and accept His sovereignty and decrees, like servants before their king.

Next time: how this improves the world, and why some siddurim say that at *Hashem Ehad* one should be ready to give one's life. "If we really believed in the Yihud Hashem, there's nothing

else which exists apart from HaKadosh Barukh Hu, then we have no hesitation in giving our life for God."

Summary

- We testify to God's unity because we cannot yet see it, which is why we cover our eyes.
- Unity has three aspects: necessary existence, sole authority, and one providence leading to one end.
- We renew this testimony morning and evening, as the world's modes change.
- Elohim is God beyond relationship; Adon Kol implies dependence; Melekh is a close relationship.
- *Barukh Shem* is our daily acceptance of God as King, for our benefit, not His.

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